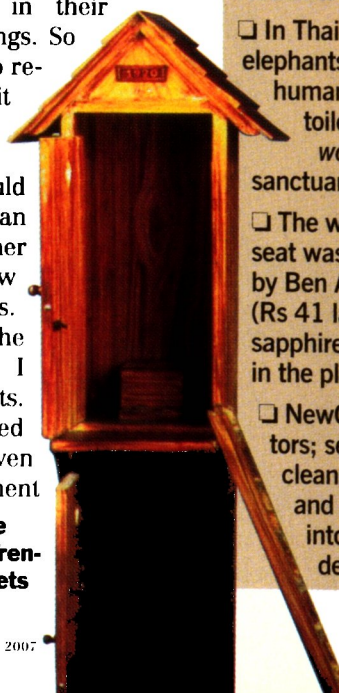


treat the night soil dump at the airport. Another visitor, Susmita Shekhar, vice president of an Indian NGO, Shangri-La Projects, says she was interested in a fungi called GE or glomus-eteruncatum that can be used to clean up sludge and septic tanks. Well, if the entire organisation is named after global trade talks, then why shouldn't a fungi be named after a multinational company? Jack admits that he had decided to call an organisation that primarily discusses something as boring as sanitation, WTO, precisely for its shock and stun value.

Experts point out that one third of the world today is deprived of such sanitation projects. Globally, 2,600 million people defecate in the open. Of these, 700 million live in India. Points out Pathak in a serious tone, "we want to halve this number by 2015 and achieve our 'toilet for all' goal by 2025." This may not be one of the goals that all aspiring Miss Universe spout when they claim that their sole aim in life is to eradicate global poverty and world illiteracy but apparently UN takes it seriously. The Netherlands' Prince of Orange, who is also the chairman of UN secretary-general's advisory board on water and sanitation, says "policy makers are usually not faced with the horrors of lacking sanitation in their personal surroundings. So we will have to keep reminding them what it is all about."

"Our scriptures say no one should defecate near human habitation. My father and my father-in-law were both doctors. One was sad and the other angry that I wanted to build toilets. But a lot has changed since then. Now even business management

IN STYLE: (clockwise from top) Austrian, French and American toilets



SEAT OF ACTION

Pathak's toilet museum showcases everything from the history of sanitation to the bizarre. Pickings:

- ❑ Even in 2500 B.C., Mohenjodaro had a highly developed sewage system that directed waste from every house into a sewer.
- ❑ First water closet was invented by England's John Harrington in 1596. He made only two, one for himself and the other for the Queen.
- ❑ The 1900s saw bathroom curtains being used in Europe. The Mughals later introduced these in India.
- ❑ In US in 1996, a hair-dresser invented a buttock stimulator for relieving constipation. An electrician, in 1992, patented the first electric chamber pot to keep warm in chilly nights.
- ❑ In Switzerland, pay toilets give you 15 minutes after which the door opens automatically, even if you're not quite done.
- ❑ The world's most expensive toilet seat was one bought by NASA from the Russians. It cost \$19 million (Rs 74 crore). It had leg restraints and thigh bars.
- ❑ In Thailand's Chiang Mai, elephants are trained to use human toilets, while in Korea toilets are called *Hae-woojae*, which means a sanctuary and a place to think.
- ❑ The world's most eclectic toilet seat was gifted to Jennifer Lopez by Ben Affleck. It cost \$105,000 (Rs 41 lakh) and had rubies, sapphire, and pearls embedded in the plastic.
- ❑ NewGen toilets have incinerators; seats that massage, cleanse with perfumed water; and portable toilets that fit into a rucksack with biodegradable starch bags.

graduates want to come into this field. Everyone is realising the value of a good toilet inside the house," says Pathak. More to the point, women no longer want to do some of their most private acts in public. Earlier, in the pre-toilet era, they had to get up at 4 a.m. and head to the fields. Now they want a bathroom within the house.

When the first public toilet was set up in Patna in 1974, Pathak was warned that he was being unduly optimistic in setting up a pay toilet in a land where people didn't even pay for their bus tickets. But Pathak has had the last laugh: "It just shows how starved people are for clean toilets".

Former President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam said at the summit that both

toilets and toilet systems were important. On display at the meet, as the most hi-tech solution to conserve water, were the incinerator toilets that don't use a flush but one kWh of electricity for each cycle and produce a spoonful of ash. The Sulabh technology, that converts waste into bio-gas which can be used for cooking and power generation,

has now been adopted by 15 countries in South Africa. The idea behind all this new-age technology is to do away with the age-old practice of using scavengers and manual labour to clean up the mess of night soil.

Then there was the eclectic toilet seat that massages, cleanses, dries and sprinkles perfumed water. Toilets that resemble airplane cockpits with a trendy lever for the flush were also on display and a throwback to the 1880s when the Austrians coloured their pots with floral prints simply because white was too cold for comfort. The bowls were so colourful that some even suggested that they could be used as soup bowls.

The final step though is still far, but when they reach it, Pathak has a doorway all set for them to walk through. The door, aptly enough, is made of recycled human waste.

